How to request access to shared drives and SharePoint sites

Article KB0010010 | Owner: Identity & Access Management | Subcategory: Access request | Applies to: All Acme Global employees, Windows 11 23H2/24H2 laptops (Dell Latitude, Lenovo ThinkPad, HP EliteBook), macOS 14/15 MacBook Pro/Air, Remote and office-based staff, Shared file servers accessed via \\fileserver*, SharePoint Online sites in Acme's Microsoft 365 tenant

Summary

This article guides Acme Global employees on how to request access to shared network drives and SharePoint sites, and explains the steps the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team takes to fulfil those requests. It includes a self-help procedure for users to submit a request via the IT self-service portal, verification steps to confirm access, and a detailed procedure for service-desk agents to process, approve, and close the ticket.

Symptoms

- Error message when opening a network folder: "You do not have permission to access \\fileserver\finance\budget.xlsx. Contact your system administrator."

Common causes

- User is not a member of the appropriate security group that grants folder or SharePoint permissions
- Manager approval has not been recorded in the request workflow
- Request submitted for the wrong resource name or path
- Group membership change has not yet replicated (up to 30 minutes delay)

Before you start

Before submitting an access request, make sure you have:

- The exact name or UNC path of the shared drive folder (e.g., \\fileserver\finance\budgets) or the full URL of the SharePoint site.
- The business justification for the access (e.g., monthly reporting, project collaboration).
- Approval from your line manager (or the manager who owns the resource). If you are a manager requesting access for a team member, you can provide the approval yourself.

Having this information ready speeds up the process and reduces back-and-forth with the IAM team.

Self-help: Request access via the IT self-service portal

Acme's IT self-service portal lets you submit an access request that routes automatically to the Identity & Access Management team for manager approval and provisioning. Follow the steps below to create a ticket.

1. Open a browser and go to the IT self-service portal: https://it.acme.example.

Click **Sign in** and authenticate with your Acme credentials (you may be prompted for MFA via Microsoft Authenticator).

On the home page, select **Access & Identity** -> **Access request**.

Choose the request type: **Shared drive folder** or **SharePoint site**.

Fill in the required fields:

- Resource details: UNC path for a drive folder *or* SharePoint site URL.
- Reason for access: brief description (max 200 characters).
- Attach any supporting documents if required (optional).
- Manager approval: either upload an approved email or select **My manager has approved** if you have already obtained verbal/written approval.

Review the information, then click **Submit**. You will receive a ticket number (e.g., REQ-2025-08734) via email and a notification in the Teams "IT Help" channel.

Keep the ticket number handy for follow-up.

Self-help: Verify your access

After you receive confirmation that the request has been processed, verify that you can reach the resource. Permissions usually propagate within 30 minutes, but you may need to sign out and back in or refresh your browser.

1. For a shared drive:

- Open File Explorer.
- Enter the UNC path you requested (e.g., \\fileserver\finance\budgets) in the address bar and press Enter.
- If the folder opens and you can view/create files, access is granted.
- If you still see an "Access denied" message, wait 10-15 minutes, then try again.

For a SharePoint site:

- Open a browser and navigate to the site URL.
- Sign in with your Acme account if prompted.
- Look for the **Settings** gear -> **Site permissions** or try to open a document library.
- If you can view/edit content, the request succeeded.
- If you receive a "You don't have permission" message, refresh the page after a few minutes or clear the browser cache.

After granting access: Confirmation and closure

After the agent has added the user to the appropriate security group, they should confirm that the user can successfully access the resource before closing the ticket. This reduces repeat contacts and ensures the request is fully satisfied.

1. Ask the user to perform the verification steps outlined in the **Self-help: Verify your access** section.

If the user reports success, add a final comment confirming verification and close the ticket with resolution **Access granted - verified**.

If the user continues to experience access denied errors:

- Double-check group membership in Azure AD (ensure the user is a member and there are no conflicting deny rules).
- Verify that the group has the correct ACL on the folder or the correct SharePoint permission level.
- If necessary, wait another 10-15 minutes and ask the user to retry.
- If the issue persists, escalate to the IAM team lead for deeper investigation (see Escalation section).

When to escalate

Escalate to the Identity & Access Management team lead (or Security Operations if the request involves sensitive data such as HR, finance, or legal) when:

- The user remains unable to access the resource after confirming correct group membership and waiting 30 minutes.
- The request lacks verifiable manager approval and the manager cannot be contacted.
- The requested resource is classified as Restricted or High-Risk and requires additional review per the Data Classification policy.

When escalating, include the ticket number, the resource identifier (UNC path or SharePoint URL), the Azure AD object ID of the user, a screenshot of any access-denied error, and a summary of the troubleshooting steps already performed.

Keywords: access request, shared drive, SharePoint, folder permission, security group, manager approval, self-service portal, IT help, identity and access management, IAM, UNc path, SharePoint site, access denied, permissions, grant access